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Kinship and Descent

The Kpelle employ an Iroquois-type system of cousin terminology, classifying siblings and parallel cousins together and distinguishing them from cross-cousins, and a bifurcate merging avuncular terminology. A listing of some kin-terms and their denotata can be found in Bellman (1975: 186–187). Certain rules of behavior are associated with this terminology. Ego's mother's brother, father's sister, and cross-cousins, are referred to as “play wives” or “play husbands” depending on ego's sex. Ego's relationship with any one of these, but especially with his ngkela (mother's brother) or maleng (cross-cousin) is a classic joking relationship: one can ask the other for favors and material things, make sexual and other jokes, and so forth. A man and his sister's son enjoy the much-studied patrilineal [43](#) African mother's brother-sister's son relationship, and a man must give his approval of and be one of the overseers of, the marriage of his sister's daughter, at least in Nyafokwele chiefdom. According to Westermann, this latter custom also existed in southwest Kpelle and after the turn of the century (1921: 55).

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